

Quality, not quantity.
Register is more important than size in corpus-based frequency estimation

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Recent evidence has shown that word frequency estimates provide a better fit to experimental data when they are based on movie subtitles, as compared to other sources such as books or written text gathered from the Internet (Brysbaert & New, 2009). Following this seminal paper, others have provided converging evidence from different languages (e.g., Cai & Brysbaert, 2010; Keuleers and Brysbaert, 2010).

In this paper we will present subtitle frequency estimates for Italian (SUBTLEX-IT) based on ~130M tokens, and we will validate them: (i) in both a lexical decision task and a more ecologically realistic eye tracking, sentence reading study; and (ii) both against a smaller (~4M tokens) corpus based on edited text (CoLFIS; Bertinetto et al., 2005) and a larger (~2B), web-crawled database (itWaC; Baroni et al., 2009). By doing so, we will yield three new contributions to the field. First, we will show that giant databases such as itWaC do not necessarily provide higher-quality frequency estimates, thus suggesting that register (i.e., quality) is more important than size (i.e., quantity). Second, we will show that eye tracking, sentence reading data allow validation of frequency corpora just as well (or even better) than lab tasks such as lexical decision. Third, we will use these higher-quality frequency measures to assess the role of this variable (taken as a sign of lexical involvement) during the various stages of visual word identification in sentence reading.

References

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